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Cover Letter

Dear Hiring Team,

What actually pulled me toward this internship was the hiring process itself. Most companies keep it vague but Verisk lays out all the stages up front before I've even applied. That's a small thing, but it's the kind of small thing that tells you more about how a place actually operates than a mission statement does. I like being able to see how a system works instead of being told to trust it, which is basically the same instinct that shows up in how I approach the rest of my problems.

Most of my time these days has gone into two internships that couldn't be more different from each other. At Clustr, I've spent months building out the backend for a React Native social app (Firebase Cloud Functions, permissions logic, community infrastructure). The unglamorous stuff that holds an app together and has disastrous consequences for every mistake. At Prenora Dynamics, I've been given full rein over a video chat feature I had to design from scratch, reading SDK documentation and making judgment calls with no one telling me the right answer. I also built a seed-data workflow there so the rest of the team could develop against our database independently instead of waiting on me, which is the closest I've come to understanding what it means to build something for other engineers rather than for an end user.

However, when somebody asks me about an interesting project I've done, my go-to is still the research I did with Ethos Lab. I designed a system that watches for newly issued SSL certificates and flags sites impersonating toll-payment services like EZ-Pass before they can scam anyone. It was a small two-person team and a lot of the work was tedious. We were writing Selenium scripts to scrape sites, building out heuristics, and staring at hundreds of flagged domains trying to tell real fraud from noise. It's the kind of project that doesn't sound impressive described in one sentence, but it's the one that actually taught me how to sit with an ambiguous problem long enough to find a real answer.

Something that's mattered to me throughout college is the role I play in my own community. I spent a year mentoring international students adjusting to life in the States, and I volunteered as a TA for Data Structures & Algorithms for similar reasons, hosting weekly recitations for students who wanted a closer, less intimidating environment to ask questions in. I learned there that explaining a concept clearly to someone who's stuck on it is its own kind of engineering problem. That's the same instinct I bring to the code I write: figure out where someone is actually confused, then build the thing that fixes it.

Thank you for the opportunity, and I'll be looking forward to hearing back from you.

Sincerely,
Hein Zarni Aung